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Uber targets the business market



Freelancer chief executive Matt Barrie said Uber's integration with work expense software, and ease of use, meant he was keen to sign on. **Photo: Dominic Lorrimer**



by **Paul Smith**

Online car hire business Uber will step up its battle with taxi giant Cabcharge on Wednesday, launching an upgraded app that aims to take the hassle out of the way companies order and pay for car travel.

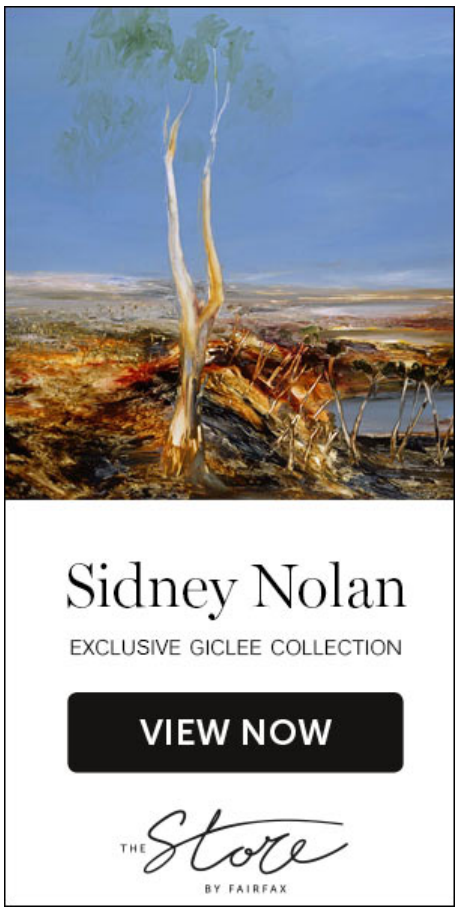
The Uber For Business product was launched in the US, Britain, France and Canada earlier this year, and will be available here from Wednesday.

It will let employees book all work car travel through the existing mobile app and have the bill sent directly to the company accounting system without the need to fiddle about with paying drivers or keeping receipts.

The launch is the latest move by Uber to disrupt the taxi industry, and local boss David Rohrsheim said there was pent-up demand for alternatives.

"Cabcharge has had a dominant position in taxi payments for a few decades ... and as a result consumers are paying too much and are still using paper receipts. We are here to offer them a new choice," Mr Rohrsheim said.

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markets. He said a number of multinationals operating in Australia, including Deutsche Bank, Barclays, Salesforce.com and Tesla had signed on.

A number of companies, including ASX-listed jobs market Freelancer.com and Wotif Group have been trial customers of the business product .

Freelancer chief executive Matt Barrie said the service's integration with work systems like SAP-owned expense software provider Concur, and ease of use, meant he was keen to sign on.

"As CEO of the world's largest crowd-sourcing marketplace, what better way is there of getting from A to B than by crowdsourcing it? That's exactly what Uber does, and it's a brilliant service," Mr Barrie said.

"Uber for Business takes it to the next level with reporting and employee management functions, andmakes life easier for our accounts team, with integrated and itemised billing."

Business customers will be able to choose from private limousine service Uber Black, Uber Taxi – available only in Sydney – Uber X private car drivers, and harbour taxis Uber Boat.

Uber has faced regulatory hurdles around the world when trying to establish itself. It is now present in 45 countries and 120 cities.

In late September the federal government's competition review backed Uber, suggesting fines doled out to Uber X drivers in Victoria for being unlicensed and a similar crackdown in NSW were more about protecting existing taxi industry businesses than fostering competition.

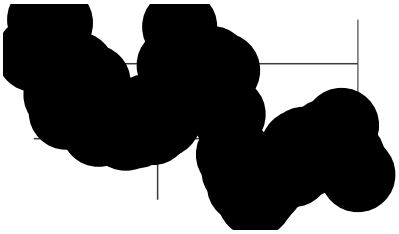
Mr Michael said regulatory wrangling was an inevitable part of industry disruption but would not stop its plans.

"The reality is that if you are disrupting a business that has stayed the same and hasn't innovated for decades, there are going to be a lot of interests that work against you," he said.

Mr Rohrsheim said he was encouraged by signs that politicians were starting to back Uber and he expected the business launch to be aided by workers who had already been using Uber in a personal capacity.

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"I am certain that there will be employees who are regular users of Uber, who are going to walk into their CFO on Wednesday and tell them to sign up."

Cabcharge declined to comment.

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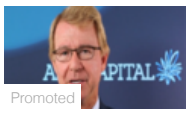


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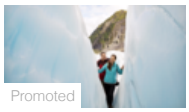
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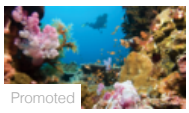
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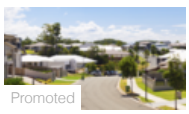
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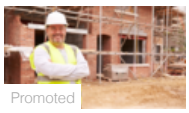
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